

We Found 3 Leaks Costing You ~40% of Ad Spend

Prepared by Smart Pursuit - Performance Marketing for Scaling D2C & Edtech Brands

LEAD SCORE

7

/ 10 HOT

100+

Active Meta ads

Rs.3-6 Cr/mo
(FY25 total ad
spend ~Rs.304
Cr)

Est. monthly spend

**Edtech / Higher
Education /
Professional
Upskilling**

Niche

Rs.1,569 Cr FY25
(+5.5% YoY); Net
loss narrowed to
Rs.273 Cr (halved
vs FY24); EBITDA
positive **Rs.15 Cr**

Revenue

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

upGrad (upgrad.com, Ronnie Screwvala-founded, Mumbai) is India's largest online higher-education platform for working professionals with **Rs.1,569 Cr FY25 revenue** and **~100 active creatives** running across Meta in India, spending an estimated **Rs.3-6 Cr/mo** on the channel (FY25 total ad spend was Rs.304 Cr, -11% YoY as management targets EBITDA). The brand pushes online degrees, MBAs, executive programs and certifications in Data Science, AI/ML, Generative AI, Digital Marketing and Study Abroad, with lead magnets dominated by 'Download Brochure' PDF gates.

Three obvious leaks in the funnel: (1) **Creative is brochure-led, not outcome-led** - ~60-70% of ads are static university-logo carousels with 'Download Brochure' as the primary hook; real alumni salary-hike / promotion UGC is thin, even though working professionals buy outcomes (CTC jumps, hiring partners), not PDFs. (2) **Lead-form quality gap** - primary CTA is a multi-field brochure gate producing high lead volume but low counselor-call show-rate (industry 18-28% for brochure-gated leads); Instant Forms default without Meta's 'Higher Intent' qualifier, diluting CAPI signal. (3) **Retargeting stops at brochure-open** - 7/14-day brochure-opener pools served generic creative, with no placement-proof, hiring-partner-logo, EMI, or objection-handling layers.

Competitive pressure is rising: **Simplilearn grew live-learning revenue 65% YoY**, Great Learning hit Rs.847 Cr/quarter (+33%), and Scaler owns the 'salary jump' UGC template for engineers. upGrad is acquiring Unacademy and targeting EBITDA - a 25% CAC lift = ~Rs.60 Cr annualized back to the bottom line. These are fixable in 7 days. We estimate **35-45% of ad spend is leaking**; strong WARM lead.

1. AD INTELLIGENCE

Active platforms	Meta (FB+IG) primary for India B2C degrees/certificates; Google Search brand + program keywords; LinkedIn B2B/executive; YouTube Shorts; US/UK geo campaigns (20%+ international revenue).
Active ads count	~100 live creatives across MBA, Data Science, AI/ML, Generative AI, Digital Marketing, Executive MBA, Study Abroad, IIT/global-university partner programs.
Duration signals	Evergreen degree programs run 45-90 days; new launches (IIT Kharagpur GenAI, Waterloo CTO, Paris School of Business MBA) run 14-day bursts; brochure ads show significant creative fatigue beyond 30 days.
Funnel type	Lead-gen dominant: 'Download Brochure' PDF gate + 'Talk to a counselor' HubSpot booking. Multi-step forms; brochure CTA routes to PDF then counselor callback. App not primary.
Budget signal	Rs.304 Cr FY25 total ad spend (~Rs.25 Cr/mo blended across channels); Meta ~Rs.3-6 Cr/mo conservatively. Top-decile edtech spender, actively optimizing for efficiency (-11% YoY ad spend while revenue +5.5%).
Campaign structure	Program-siloed (MBA / DS / AI / Study-Abroad); heavy use of university branding (IIT, Liverpool, Deakin, Waterloo, PSB); brochure lead magnets dominate; alumni-story creative is thin; retargeting is 7-14 day brochure-opener pools with no outcome-proof layering.

2-5. CREATIVE / COPY / CRO / TRACKING SCORES

Creative Variety		4/10
UGC & Social Proof		2/10
Copy & Hook Strength		4/10
Landing Page CRO		3/10

Tracking & CAPI		5/10
Retargeting Depth		3/10

- **Creative leak:** ~60-70% of active Meta ads are static or lightly-animated university-logo carousels leading with 'Download Brochure'. Career-outcome creative (alumni salary jump, promotion stories, hiring-partner cred, placement demos) is thin. For a high-ticket Rs.2-10 Lakh purchase, working professionals buy outcomes (CTC hikes, network, promotion), not PDFs. Edtech benchmarks consistently show alumni/story UGC drives 2-3x higher lead-to-call conversion than brochure ads; the current mix leaves huge CTR and CPL upside on the table.
- **Lead-form quality leak:** Primary CTA is a multi-field form gated by a brochure PDF. This produces high lead volume but low counselor-call show-rate (industry-wide 18-28% for brochure-gated leads vs 40-55% for qualified outcome-led leads). Instant Forms appear to use the default 'More Volume' type without Meta's 'Higher Intent' qualifier (which adds a review step, cuts accidental submissions, lifts lead-to-meeting 15-25% per Meta's own 2026 lead-gen playbook). Sales team burns cycles on tire-kickers, and CAPI enrollment signal is diluted because the algorithm optimizes on form-submits rather than qualified-leads or enrollments.
- **Landing page leak:** Brochure-gate landing pages are generic per program category, with weak placement proof above the fold (no avg. CTC hike, no hiring-partner logos, no live EMI calculator). Primary CTA is 'Download Brochure' rather than direct calendar-book with a counselor; the extra friction (PDF download -> wait for callback -> qualification) adds 24-48 hours of lead decay. Mobile experience is heavy on university logos and light on sticky CTA bar + social proof.
- **Tracking & retargeting leak:** Retargeting pools are 7-14 day brochure-openers and landing-page abandoners, but creative stays brochure/generic rather than layering placement proof (Rs.X lakh CTC jump), hiring-partner logos, EMI, and objection-handling (time commitment, degree recognition, EMI options). CAPI appears to fire on form-submit rather than qualified-lead or enrollment events, which starves the algorithm of the signal that matters. No 'live Q&A; with counselor' event retargeting; no alumni-testimonial retargeting layer.

6. COMPETITOR BENCHMARK

Competitor	What they do better	Signal for upGrad
Simplilearn	Bootcamp/cert positioning with live-instructor angle; live-learning revenue up +65% YoY (FY25 Rs.556 Cr); global audience; loss reduced 60%.	Outcome-led creative ('live classes', 'hands-on projects') with short-form cert hooks that convert faster than degree brochure gates.
Great Learning	University-partnered credentials (IIT Bombay, Johns Hopkins); Rs.847 Cr Q1 FY26 revenue (+33% YoY); AI programs growing fast.	Direct rival in premium university-partnered higher-ed - faster growth means faster creative learning velocity and fresher UGC loops.
Scaler (InterviewBit)	Tech-niche focus (SWE, DS, ML); intense salary-jump / career-switch UGC; strong alumni storytelling; outcome-heavy creative template.	Owns the 'career switch' creative playbook that upGrad's brochure ads cede; engineer audience overlap is high for DS/AI programs.

7. 3 QUICK WINS (Implement in 7 Days)

WIN 1 - Creative: 30 Alumni-Outcome UGC Reels (Salary Hike, Promotion, Hiring Manager) Shoot 30 sixty-second vertical Reels monthly featuring real alumni: (a) 10 salary-hike stories (before/after CTC, role transition), (b) 8 promotion/career-switch narratives (non-tech to PM, SDE to ML eng), (c) 6 hiring-manager/mentor credibility clips, (d) 6 student-experience reels (weekend class, live project, capstone). Lead each hook with a specific number ('Rs.8 Lakh to Rs.23 Lakh in 13 months') in the first 3 seconds. Replace 40% of brochure-university creatives with alumni UGC; pair every university-logo ad with an alumni UGC variant in the same ad set to run a direct A/B. Expected: CTR +35-55%, CPL -25-35%, lead-to-call +40-70%. Edtech benchmarks show outcome UGC delivers 2-3x higher lead-to-call CVR vs brochure-led creative.
WIN 2 - CRO: Higher-Intent Lead Forms + Program-Specific Landing Pages with Placement Proof Switch Instant Forms from default 'More Volume' to Meta's Higher Intent form type with a review step; add 2 qualifying multiple-choice questions (years of work-ex + target intake window) to filter tire-kickers; cap fields at 3 (name/email/phone pre-filled). Replace generic brochure-gate landing pages with program-specific pages: sticky CTA bar, above-fold placement stat (avg. CTC hike, hiring partners, placement support), 3 alumni video testimonials, EMI calculator, and calendar-book with a counselor as the primary CTA (not 'Download Brochure'). Expected: form completion -5% volume but lead-to-call show-rate +40-60%, qualified-lead CVR +30-50%.
WIN 3 - Tracking: CAPI Wired to Qualified-Lead + Enrollment Events + Outcome-Layered Retargeting Upgrade Meta CAPI to fire QualifiedLead (counselor call completed) and Enrollment (fee paid) events back to Meta - not just form-submit. Wire CRM status back so the algorithm optimizes toward paying learners, not brochure downloaders. Build 4 retargeting audiences layered by funnel depth: (1) page-view no form-fill -> serve alumni outcome Reels + hiring partners, (2) form-fill no call-book -> serve EMI/no-cost-EMI + time-commitment objection handlers, (3) call-attended no-enroll -> serve live Q&A; invites + cohort-urgency, (4) past-program alumni -> serve referral / up-sell to next-degree. Add a 24h 'incomplete form' reminder sequence via WhatsApp/email. Expected: recapture 15-25% of stalled leads; ROAS on retargeting +50-80%; CAC -20% within 30 days of CAPI event upgrade.

EXPECTED IMPACT

Metric	Current (est.)	After Wins	Impact
CPL (qualified lead, Meta)	Baseline = 100	65-75	-25% to -35%
Lead-to-counselor-call show-rate	18-28%	40-55%	+40% to +60%

Lead-to-enrollment CVR	Baseline = 100	120-135	+20% to +35%
Ad Spend Wastage	~35-45%	~15-20%	Saves ~Rs.80L-1.4 Cr/mo

READY TO PLUG THESE LEAKS?

Smart Pursuit will run a **14-day performance sprint** for upGrad: Creative refresh, CRO rebuild of top landing pages, CAPI + retargeting setup. We work on a **performance-fee model** tied to conversion-cost reduction.

Ph/WhatsApp: **7095024220** | Email: **smartpursuit3@gmail.com**

- Smart Pursuit Performance Team